

and Nottingham Forest (Oliver Glasner) all have new individuals at the helm and are poised to cause disruption and ensure that there will be no easy games in a season that is bound to set the tone for the coming years.

La Liga

La Liga has mostly been a two-horse race since the turn of the decade, and that trend is likely to continue, with the skirmish between Barcelona and Real Madrid beginning well before the start of the season.

Star power has been what has set these giants apart from the rest of the competition, and this summer was no different. Barcelona acquired the services of Anthony Gordon (**below**) and Karim Adeyemi from Newcastle United and Borussia Dortmund, respectively, but Real Madrid certainly won the battle before the war.

Apart from convincing 'special one' Jose Mourinho to return as head coach to manage the big names, Los Blancos strengthened their already stacked squad by bringing in Marc Cucurella, Bernardo Silva, Denzel Dumfries, Ibrahima Konate and Yan Diomande. They also managed to get Vinicius Jr to stay amidst talks of him joining Arsenal and look primed and ready to try and end the two-year title drought.

However, Barcelona might just have the final say in this transfer saga, as it has reportedly agreed personal terms to sign Rodri from Manchester City, after the 30-year-old spent most of the summer being linked to Real. If Barca manages to pull it off, Rodri will be reunited with his World Cup-winning teammates like Pedri and Dani Olmo in midfield, significantly boosting Hansi Flick's chances of making it three league titles in a row.

Atletico Madrid, meanwhile, has played third fiddle all these years, and after finishing fourth and reaching the final and semifinal of the Copa del Rey and Champions League last season, the pressure will



Fresh reinforcement: Inter Milan has bolstered its defence by signing John Stones from Manchester City on a free transfer. REUTERS



be mounting on Diego Simeone to produce some silverware. With a big figure like Antoine Griezmann having left the club, a lot of Atletico's performance will depend on whether it can hold onto Julian Alvarez, who has been eyed by the ruling duopoly.

Elsewhere, Real Betis emerged as one of the surprise packages of last season under the leadership of the experienced Manuel Pellegrini, finishing fifth in the standings. It will be in action in the Champions League for the first time after its only appearance in the 2005-06 season, and while it may not be able to keep up with the giants, Betis will surely play its part in keeping the opponents on their toes.

Serie A

Italian football is perhaps at the lowest it has been in recent memory, with the men's national team failing to qualify for a third straight World Cup. And, with the next World Cup cycle beginning now, Serie A will have the task of ensuring the standards do not drop even further. But despite its shortcomings, the Italian top tier produced one of the closest title races last season, with Inter Milan securing its 21st Scudetto.

Cristian Chivu's squad has remained largely intact, apart from a few departures, including Denzel Dumfries, who swapped the blue and black for the white of Real Madrid. But a sufficient replacement in defence was found in the form of John Stones, who joined the club on a free transfer from Manchester City. Napoli and Roma are set to be Inter's closest challengers for the crown, with the former hoping to have a smooth start to life under new manager Massimiliano Allegri, who replaced Antonio Conte.

For Roma, Gian Piero Gasperini will head into his second season looking to improve on the third-place finish last season.

Surprisingly, neither side has chosen to massively tinker with the current bunch of players available at their disposal.